

THE 'N' FACTORS
Nitish and Naidu greet Prime Minister Modi in New Delhi, Jun. 5

to account and hammer out a consensus on how to rapidly address issues such as rising unemployment and inflation that continue to beset the country. If Modi was disappointed with the BJP not winning a majority on its own, it didn't show as he entered the BJP headquarters in Delhi soon after the results were announced and was greeted with a shower of rose petals by the party's supporters. His address was brief, but he made it clear that he would lead the nation again and work with NDA partners. "The NDA's third term will see a new golden chapter in India's development... this is Modi's guarantee," he said. "It also strengthens our resolve for a Viksit Bharat."

BRAND MODI ON THE WANE

While the BJP may not admit it, experts believe that the results do show that Modi's electoral invincibility has been seriously dented. Especially because he made Election 2024 a presidential-style campaign, holding over 180 rallies across the country, promising everyone "*Modi ki guarantee*". He also set an ambitious target of 370 seats for the BJP and pushed for a super-majority of 400-plus along with NDA partners. Many saw this stemming from his desire to equal Rajiv Gandhi's feat of winning 414 seats for the Congress in 1984. In the event, the BJP's final tally of 240 seats, though creditable, seems like a huge comedown. Political analyst Amitabh Tiwari likens the progress of Brand Modi to what management experts consider the four stages of a product's life-cycle—introduction, growth, maturity and decline. The election results, he believes, demonstrate that Modi has crossed the maturity stage and is headed for decline.

Tiwari bolsters his argument with the post-poll analysis by the Lokniti programme of the Delhi-based Centre for the Study of Developing Societies (CSDS), which shows that while Modi remained the leading choice of voters to become prime minister, his numbers had declined from 47 per cent in a similar poll in 2019 to 41 per cent now—a drop of six percentage points. "There is a clear plateauing of support for Brand Modi," says Sandeep Shastri, national coordinator of Lokniti-CSDS. For Tiwari, in that decline lies the possible reason for the current fall in BJP numbers since the party depended extensively on the 'Modi premium' to fetch votes for it. Interestingly, the same study showed the gap between Modi and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi narrowing from 24 percentage points in 2019 to 14 this time.

Other studies suggest that Modi's overzealous pitch for a